

Robert Falls

Executive Summary

Robert Arthur Falls, born March 2, 1954, in Springfield, Illinois, grew up in rural Illinois, studied directing and playwriting at the University of Illinois, and became one of the defining American regional-theatre directors of the late twentieth and early twenty-first centuries. His rise came fast. Within months of graduating in 1976, he launched a professional Chicago career with Moonchildren, won an early Joseph Jefferson Award, then won another for *Of Mice and Men* at Wisdom Bridge Theatre, which hired him as artistic director when he was still in his early twenties. At Wisdom Bridge he built a reputation for scale, emotional extremity, and formal boldness in classics and new work. In 1986 he moved to the Goodman Theatre and stayed for 36 years, turning the company into a national institution with Broadway transfers, a Tony-winning regional profile, a new downtown complex, an Artistic Collective model, and a repertoire that alternated ambitious classics with new plays and world premieres. ¹

As a director, Falls was drawn to “big, passionate, messy works,” and both admirers and detractors saw his signature clearly. Admirers praised his appetite for scale, pressure, danger, and vivid stage pictures. Critics quoted on Goodman materials and in press profiles described him as unusually strong at making canonical moments “pop,” and Chris Jones identified large-scale ambition as one of his signature traits. Falls himself acknowledged a recurring criticism, that he could underline dramatic moments “with a heavy hand.” Those two readings fit together. His theatre often aimed for maximum impact, not neutrality. ²

His most important artistic partnership was with Brian Dennehy. Their repeated work on O’Neill, Miller, and Brecht helped define Falls’s national standing. *Death of a Salesman* won the 1999 Tony Award for Best Revival of a Play, Brian Dennehy won for Willy Loman, Elizabeth Franz won for Linda, and Falls himself won Best Direction of a Play. *Long Day’s Journey Into Night* transferred from the Goodman and won major awards as well. On Broadway, Falls also directed or co-created *Aida*, *Shining City*, *Talk Radio*, *The Young Man from Atlanta*, *The Night of the Iguana*, and *The Rose Tattoo*. ³

Institutionally, Falls mattered almost as much as artistically. During his and Roche Schulfer’s leadership, Goodman attendance averaged 90 percent capacity, subscriptions exceeded 23,000, sales revenue grew from \$2.5 million to \$8.5 million, public support grew from \$1.5 million to \$5.6 million, and the company completed its \$46 million downtown complex, which opened in 2000. By the mid-2020s, the Goodman reported an operating budget above \$22 million, roughly 375 annual performances, and annual attendance above 230,000. The company also later established the Alice C. Rapoport Center for Education and Engagement in 2017. ⁴

This report covers the following dimensions explicitly: biography; education and early life; production history across Wisdom Bridge, Goodman, Broadway, regional theatre, Off-Broadway, and opera; Jeff Awards evidence; major collaborations; directing style; Wisdom Bridge context and departure; Goodman institutional impact; Broadway transfer outcomes; opera work and reception; controversies and critical pushback; designer collaborations; diversity, equity, anti-racism, and the Goodman’s response to *We See You*, *White American Theater*; mentorship and influence; relationship with critics; late-career freelance

work; and publicly available observations about temperament. Where records were incomplete, I say so directly.

Biography and Career Arc

Falls was born in Springfield, Illinois, on March 2, 1954, and grew up in rural Illinois before his family moved to Urbana. Britannica says he began staging puppet shows and directing friends as a child, then deepened his interest after moving and immersing himself in movies and live theatre; Chicago Magazine adds his own recollection that he was a self-conscious “oddity” in a small Illinois town, already memorizing cast albums and building theatrical scrapbooks when he was very young. He earned a B.F.A. in playwriting and directing from the University of Illinois in 1976 and briefly studied acting in New York before returning to Chicago.

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The early-career pattern was already visible. Falls tried acting, was told he was too tall for it, and shifted harder toward directing and writing. The University of Illinois profile says he interrupted his New York acting pursuit to remount his university production of Michael Weller’s *Moonchildren* for Apollo Productions in Chicago. That production earned his first Jeff Award. A year later, his *Of Mice and Men* at Wisdom Bridge earned a second Jeff Award and led to his appointment as artistic director there.

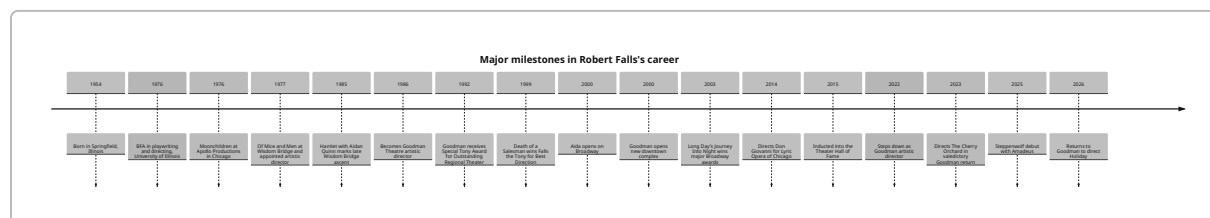
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Falls’s public comments about temperament are unusually consistent across decades. He has presented himself as socially perceptive, intensely actor-centered, emotionally volatile during rehearsal, and uninterested in blandness. He told Chicago Magazine that he relies on a “high social IQ,” that actors need to feel “safe and protected,” and that he would rather leave audiences angry than unaffected. In the same piece, he described the first weeks of rehearsal as cycling from euphoria to self-loathing. American Theatre, writing after his Goodman departure, likewise presented him as a physically imposing but collaborative leader who did not run the theatre as an “aesthetic autocrat.”

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The major milestones below are drawn from official and high-confidence public records.

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Falls’s public-facing photo and production galleries are unusually well preserved. Goodman’s press-room archive page for him includes downloadable headshots and production photos for *Uncle Vanya*, *2666*, and *Soups, Stews, and Casseroles*: 1976. Steppenwolf’s *Amadeus* page includes rehearsal and production photography, and the Goodman’s *Holiday* page serves as the official production hub for his 2026 return.

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Production Record

No single public source surfaced a fully enumerated, collaborator-complete, season-by-season record for every Wisdom Bridge and Goodman title. Goodman’s official season archive is strong on season contents,

and Falls's official bios identify many titles, but the accessible public web record still leaves gaps. The table below therefore consolidates the titles, venues, collaborators, and awards or outcomes that were verifiable from the sources gathered, and it separates confirmed facts from unknowns. ¹⁰

Verified production chronology

Year or season	Production	Venue	Key collaborators verified in accessible sources	Awards or outcomes	Source
1976	Moonchildren	Apollo Productions, Chicago	Falls remounted his University of Illinois staging	Earned Falls his first Jeff Award, category not specified in accessible source	¹¹
1977	Of Mice and Men	Wisdom Bridge Theatre	Not specified in accessible source	Earned Falls his second Jeff Award, category not specified in accessible source; led to artistic-director appointment	¹²
1979	Wings	Wisdom Bridge Theatre	Not specified in accessible source	Confirmed Wisdom Bridge credit	¹³
1980	Travesties	Wisdom Bridge Theatre	Not specified in accessible source	Confirmed Wisdom Bridge credit	¹³
1981	Mother Courage and Her Children	Wisdom Bridge Theatre	Not specified in accessible source	Falls later cited it as evidence he had outgrown Wisdom Bridge's scale	¹⁴
1982	A Streetcar Named Desire	Wisdom Bridge Theatre	Tennessee Williams attended a performance, per Falls's recollection	Confirmed Wisdom Bridge credit	¹⁵
1983	In the Belly of the Beast	Wisdom Bridge Theatre	Adaptation of Jack Abbott letters	Confirmed Wisdom Bridge credit	¹³

Year or season	Production	Venue	Key collaborators verified in accessible sources	Awards or outcomes	Source
1985	Hamlet	Wisdom Bridge Theatre, later remounted at Civic Opera	Aidan Quinn starred as Hamlet; Del Close played Polonius	Signature late Wisdom Bridge production	16
1980s	Standing on My Knees	Wisdom Bridge Theatre, later Manhattan Theatre Club	World premiere by John Olive	Transferred to Manhattan Theatre Club	11
1986-87	Galileo	Goodman Theatre	Brian Dennehy	Falls's Goodman directorial debut as artistic director	17
1987-88	Pal Joey	Goodman Theatre	Falls wrote a new book; other collaborators not specified in gathered official sources	One of his early major Goodman landmarks	18
1988-89	The Speed of Darkness	Goodman Theatre	Play by Steve Tesich	Confirmed Goodman credit	19
1989-90	The Misanthrope	Goodman Theatre	Not specified in accessible source	Confirmed Goodman credit	18
1990-91	The Iceman Cometh	Goodman Theatre	Later strongly associated with Brian Dennehy and, in later revivals, Nathan Lane	2012 revival later won a Jeff Award; production also later played BAM	20
1991-92	On the Open Road	Goodman Theatre	Play by Steve Tesich	Confirmed Goodman credit	21
1991-92	Riverview: A Melodrama with Music	Goodman Theatre	Play by John Logan	Confirmed Goodman credit	21

Year or season	Production	Venue	Key collaborators verified in accessible sources	Awards or outcomes	Source
1993-94	The Night of the Iguana	Goodman Theatre	Later Broadway cast included Cherry Jones, Marsha Mason, William Petersen, Mary Beth Fisher	Transferred to Broadway in 1996	22
1994-95	Three Sisters	Goodman Theatre	Not specified in accessible source	Confirmed Goodman credit	21
1995-96	A Touch of the Poet	Goodman Theatre	Brian Dennehy	Part of major Falls-Dennehy O'Neill cycle	21
1996-97	The Young Man from Atlanta	Goodman Theatre, then Broadway	Broadway cast included Shirley Knight and Rip Torn	Broadway transfer in 1997	23
1997-98	Griller	Goodman Theatre	Play by Eric Bogosian	Confirmed Goodman credit	24
1998-99	Death of a Salesman	Goodman Theatre, then Broadway	Brian Dennehy, Elizabeth Franz, Kevin Anderson, Howard Witt; Mark Wendland, Birgit Rattenborg Wise, Michael S. Philippi, Richard Woodbury	Best Revival Tony; Falls won Best Direction Tony	25
1999-00	A Moon for the Misbegotten	Goodman Theatre	Not specified in accessible source	Continued Dennehy and O'Neill association	21
2000	Aida	Broadway	Elton John, Tim Rice, Linda Woolverton, David Henry Hwang, Wayne Cilento, Bob Crowley, Natasha Katz, Heather Headley, Adam Pascal, Sherie Rene Scott	1,852-performance run; four Tony wins for the production	26

Year or season	Production	Venue	Key collaborators verified in accessible sources	Awards or outcomes	Source
2002-03	Long Day's Journey Into Night	Goodman Theatre, then Broadway	Brian Dennehy, Vanessa Redgrave, Philip Seymour Hoffman, Robert Sean Leonard; Santo Loquasto, Brian MacDevitt, Richard Woodbury	Major Broadway revival; Drama Desk recognition and Tony wins for the production	27
2004-05	Finishing the Picture	Goodman Theatre	Arthur Miller's last play	Important world premiere in Falls tenure	28
2005-06	Shining City	Manhattan Theatre Club, Broadway	Oliver Platt, Brían F. O'Byrne, Martha Plimpton, Peter Scanavino; Santo Loquasto, Kaye Voyce, Christopher Akerlind	80 performances; Tony nomination for Best Play	29
2006-07	King Lear	Goodman Theatre	Stacy Keach in title role	Falls later cited a Helen Hayes Award for this production	30
2006-07	Talk Radio	Broadway	Liev Schreiber-led Broadway production; Mark Wendland, Laura Bauer, Christopher Akerlind, Richard Woodbury	121 performances; nomination activity around the production	31
2009	Desire Under the Elms	Goodman Theatre, then Broadway	Brian Dennehy; designer Walt Spangler	Strong and divided reception; transferred to Broadway	32
2010	The Seagull	Goodman Theatre	Not specified in accessible source	Falls later called it "life-changing" in retrospect	33
2012	The Iceman Cometh	Goodman Theatre	Nathan Lane headed the later BAM presentation of this production	2012 Jeff Award named on Goodman bio; BAM transfer in 2015	34

Year or season	Production	Venue	Key collaborators verified in accessible sources	Awards or outcomes	Source
2012-13	The Jacksonian	Goodman Theatre, Los Angeles, Off-Broadway	Beth Henley play	World and Off-Broadway premieres noted in Goodman bio	35
2014	Luna Gale	Goodman Theatre, later CTG Kirk Douglas	Rebecca Gilman play	Remounted in Los Angeles	36
2014	Don Giovanni	Lytic Opera of Chicago	Walt Spangler, Ana Kuzmanic, Duane Schuler; Mariusz Kwiecień, Ana María Martínez, Kyle Ketelsen in press coverage	Falls's first Lyric opera since The Consul	37
2015-16	Soups, Stews, and Casseroles: 1976	Goodman Theatre	Cliff Chamberlain, Cora Vander Broek, Lindsay Stock, Angela Reed, Ty Olwin in official photo archive	Confirmed Goodman credit	35
2015-16	2666	Goodman Theatre	Co-adapted and co-directed with Seth Bockley; Henry Godinez and large ensemble visible in official photo archive	Jeff Award for Best Adaptation	35
2016-17	Uncle Vanya	Goodman Theatre	Annie Baker adaptation; Tim Hopper, Marton Csokas, Kristen Bush in official photo archive	Major late-career Goodman classic	35
2016-17	Pamplona	Goodman Theatre	Jim McGrath play; Stacy Keach starred	Major late-Falls world premiere	38
2017-18	An Enemy of the People	Goodman Theatre	Falls wrote the adaptation	Seen by critics as emphasizing Ibsen's dark absurdity	39

Year or season	Production	Venue	Key collaborators verified in accessible sources	Awards or outcomes	Source
2018-19	We're Only Alive for A Short Amount of Time	Goodman Theatre, later Public Theater	David Cale created and performed	Transferred to the Public Theater	40
2018-19	The Winter's Tale	Goodman Theatre	Walt Spangler and Ana Kuzmanic listed in Goodman program excerpt; official press room carries critical praise	Strong praise with some pushback	41
2019-20	Molly Sweeney	Goodman Theatre	Brian Friel play	Planned as a major late Goodman project	42
2021	The Sound Inside	Goodman Theatre Live series	Mary Beth Fisher and John Drea in WTTW coverage	Pandemic live-stream project	43
2022-23	The Cherry Orchard	Goodman Theatre	Kast included Kate Fry and Kareem Bandealy in Sun-Times coverage	Widely treated as valedictory Goodman return	44
2022-23	Swing State	Goodman Theatre, later Off-Broadway	Rebecca Gilman; Mary Beth Fisher and Kristen Fitzgerald highlighted in Chicago review aggregation	Marked his most recent Goodman staging listed on current artist page	45
2025-26	Amadeus	Steppenwolf	Ian Barford, Ora Jones, Robert Breuler, Yassen Peyankov; large-cast Steppenwolf debut	Marked a conspicuous late-career freelance shift	46
2026	Holiday	Goodman Theatre	Richard Greenberg adaptation of Philip Barry; official Goodman production page	Falls's return to Goodman as guest director	47

Broadway outcomes

Production	Falls credit	Open and close	Previews and performances	Theatre	Tony and major awards outcome	Critical reception snapshot	Source
The Rose Tattoo	Director	Apr. 30 to Jul. 2, 1995	10 previews, 73 performances	Circle in the Square	Best Revival of a Play nominee; no Best Direction nomination recorded on IBDB page	Production was part of Falls's early Broadway profile, but not a major awards breakthrough	48
The Night of the Iguana	Director	Mar. 21 to May 19, 1996	18 previews, 69 performances	Criterion Center Stage Right	Award details not surfaced in the lines gathered here	Variety's summary was mixed, saying Falls got mixed results from his cast	49
The Young Man from Atlanta	Director	Mar. 27 to Jun. 8, 1997	17 previews, 84 performances	Longacre	Tony nominations for Best Play, Best Actress, and Best Featured Actor	Respectful reception, with nominations but no major Tony win for Falls or direction	50
Death of a Salesman	Director	Feb. 10 to Nov. 7, 1999	22 previews, 274 performances	Eugene O'Neill	Won Best Revival of a Play; Brian Dennehy won; Elizabeth Franz won; Falls won Best Direction of a Play	This was the defining Broadway triumph of his career	51

Production	Falls credit	Open and close	Previews and performances	Theatre	Tony and major awards outcome	Critical reception snapshot	Source
Aida	Director and co-book writer	Mar. 23, 2000 to Sept. 5, 2004	30 previews, 1,852 performances	Palace	Four Tony wins for the production, including score, actress, scenic design, and lighting; no Best Direction win recorded in gathered lines	Commercially his biggest Broadway success by far	26
Long Day's Journey Into Night	Director	May 6 to Aug. 31, 2003	10 previews, 117 performances	Plymouth	The production won major Broadway awards; Goodman and Illinois sources emphasize Tony success	A prestige transfer built around Dennehy, Redgrave, Hoffman, and Leonard	27
Shining City	Director	May 9 to Jul. 16, 2006	21 previews, 80 performances	Biltmore	Tony nomination for Best Play; Oliver Platt nominated for Best Actor	Variety praised the cast and the production's naturalism	52

Production	Falls credit	Open and close	Previews and performances	Theatre	Tony and major awards outcome	Critical reception snapshot	Source
Talk Radio	Director	Mar. 11 to Jun. 24, 2007	29 previews, 121 performances	Longacre	Tony-nomination activity attached to the production in 2007; the accessible lines here do not isolate the exact category list	Reception stressed performance energy more than textual revelation	53

Jeff Awards record

A complete nomination-by-nomination Jeff Awards reconstruction was not possible from the accessible public web record gathered here. The official Jeff archive surfaced in search, but not in a reliably complete way for Falls's entire career. The safest course is to distinguish what is securely verified from what remains open. 54

Verified Jeff item	Evidence	Source
Moonchildren earned Falls his first Jeff Award	University of Illinois profile states this directly, but does not specify category in the accessible text	11
Of Mice and Men earned Falls his second Jeff Award	University of Illinois profile states this directly, but does not specify category in the accessible text	11
The Iceman Cometh won a 2012 Jeff Award	Goodman's official Robert Falls press-room bio states this directly	35
2666 received the Jeff Award for Best Adaptation	Goodman's official Robert Falls press-room bio states this directly	35
Goodman under Falls's tenure accumulated more than 160 Jeff Awards	Playbill's report on his departure states this institutional total	55

Artistic Practice and Collaborations

Falls's own description of his taste is the right starting point. In a 2006 Chicago Magazine profile he said he is drawn to "big, passionate, messy works, messy emotions, messy people, messy lives." Chris Jones

similarly identified “the big project” as one of Falls’s signatures, praising his willingness to attempt work of “heft and ambition and scale” when many regional theatres were programming smaller, safer plays. Falls’s long-form experiments, such as 2666 and *The Iceman Cometh*, fit that profile exactly. ⁵⁶

Goodman’s own promotional archive preserves a succinct critical consensus about his style. For *The Winter’s Tale*, the press room quoted the *Chicago Tribune* calling him unmatched among modern American directors at making “iconic moments pop with fresh irreverence.” Even when one strips away the publicity language, the point is useful. Falls’s best work often depended on re-energizing familiar classics through concrete stage events, strong sensory cues, and visibly risk-seeking performances rather than through academic reverence. ⁵⁷

The persistent criticism was parallel. Falls told *Chicago Magazine* in 2010 that “there are those who accuse me of underlining with a heavy hand.” That is less a contradiction than the other side of the same method. He favored emphasis. He liked detonations, vivid physical images, and emotional overpressure. In reviews, that could read as thrilling clarity or as overstatement. *Desire Under the Elms* drew praise from *Variety* for its daring set and from positive reviewers for its concentrated sensual violence, but other critics found elements of the staging magnified beyond necessity. *The Winter’s Tale* was warmly received by some, while others thought the storytelling shifted too abruptly in tone. ⁵⁸

Brian Dennehy was the central actor collaboration. Public records and biographical sources tie Dennehy to *Galileo*, *The Iceman Cometh*, *A Touch of the Poet*, *Death of a Salesman*, *Long Day’s Journey Into Night*, *Hughie*, and *Desire Under the Elms*. This partnership mattered because it gave Falls an actor with the physical force, authority, and emotional amplitude his productions often demanded. The Dennehy cycle also sharpened Falls’s standing as a modern interpreter of O’Neill and Miller. ⁵⁹

Other verified collaborations include Aidan Quinn in *Hamlet* at Wisdom Bridge, Stacy Keach in *King Lear* and Pamplona, Nathan Lane in the BAM presentation of *The Iceman Cometh*, and Cherry Jones in the Broadway transfer of *The Night of the Iguana*. Those pairings show the range of Falls’s casting practice. He worked with Chicago-rooted actors, major Broadway and film names, and performers who could handle dense classical language or emotionally punishing contemporary writing. In the publicly accessible sources gathered here, I did not locate a clean primary source tying Falls to every name in the user’s suggested list, especially Elizabeth Marvel, Deanna Dunagan, and Janet McTeer, so I do not assign those pairings without stronger documentation. ⁶⁰

Falls’s designer collaborations point to a recognizable visual aesthetic. Walt Spangler appears repeatedly in connection with *Desire Under the Elms*, *The Jacksonian*, 2666, *King Lear*, *Measure for Measure*, and *The Winter’s Tale*. Ana Kuzmanic appears on a parallel track, including *An Enemy of the People*, *Uncle Vanya*, *Wonderful Town*, 2666, *Measure for Measure*, *Desire Under the Elms*, and *The Winter’s Tale*. On Broadway and in opera he also worked with major designers such as Santo Loquasto, Mark Wendland, Michael Yeargan, Bob Crowley, and Natasha Katz. The pattern suggests a director who valued architectural environments, strong spatial metaphors, and a controlled fusion of realism with stylization. ⁶¹

Opera extended, rather than contradicted, his theatre work. Lyric Opera’s official artist page says he made his Lyric debut with *Susannah*, later directed *The Consul*, and returned for *Don Giovanni*. A Lyric-related feature and Dallas Opera materials show *Don Giovanni* built with Walt Spangler, Ana Kuzmanic, and Duane Schuler, while criticism emphasized its noir-inflected, early-twentieth-century Spanish setting and carnal danger. For *Susannah*, sources tie the production to Lyric, the Metropolitan Opera, and Houston. Reception

at the Met was warm to the clarity and plain-spokenness of Falls's staging, though the production's simple Americana also divided some critics. ⁶²

Institutional Impact at Wisdom Bridge and Goodman

At Wisdom Bridge, Falls learned both artistic leadership and scarcity. His own recollection of that job is blunt. At 23, artistic direction still meant cleaning toilets in the morning before opening the box office. Publicly accessible sources gathered here did not surface hard budget, attendance, or audited box-office data for Wisdom Bridge, so any quantitative account of that era would be conjectural. What is clear is the artistic trajectory. By his own later account, productions like *Hamlet* and *Mother Courage* had become too large for the scale of the company, and he increasingly wanted "big Brecht productions" and "large Shakespeare." In *American Theatre* he said plainly that he had outgrown Wisdom Bridge. ⁶³

The move to the Goodman in 1986 was not inevitable. Falls told *American Theatre* that the board was split on hiring him and that the theatre was carrying a multimillion-dollar deficit when he arrived. He described himself as a cocky, aggressive candidate with expensive artistic ambitions at a moment when some trustees wanted a more conservative path. That matters because it shows how much of the Goodman story was strategic as well as aesthetic. Falls and executive director Roche Schulfer built a case for scale. ⁶⁴

The numbers support that reading. A 2006 theatre profile said that under Falls and Schulfer the Goodman averaged 90 percent capacity, surpassed 23,000 subscribers, increased sales revenue from \$2.5 million to \$8.5 million, and lifted public support from \$1.5 million to \$5.6 million. The same source credits them with building the \$46 million Dearborn Street complex, opened in fall 2000, which helped spur the North Loop theatre district. Goodman's current financial page describes the institution at a later scale of more than \$22 million in annual budget, about 375 performances, and more than 230,000 attendees, which helps show the durable institutional footprint left by the Falls era. A later Goodman executive-news item also credits longtime leadership with stewarding the move and establishing the Alice C. Rapoport Center for Education and Engagement in 2017. ⁴

The capital structure is partially visible in the Goodman's financial statements. A 2014-15 audited statement notes that the Illinois Development Finance Authority issued \$24.1 million in Adjustable Rate Demand Revenue Bonds in 1999 for the Goodman Theatre project. That does not give a complete capital-campaign map on its own, but it confirms that the downtown transformation involved major bond financing in addition to contributed support. ⁶⁵

One of Falls's most consequential institutional ideas was the Artistic Collective. *American Theatre* describes him as fostering a collective with a genuine stake in programming rather than running the Goodman as a one-man aesthetic regime. Falls himself said the collective idea was central from the beginning and that he wanted colleagues around him rather than the isolation he felt at Wisdom Bridge. Public Goodman-related sources identify artists such as Frank Galati, Michael Maggio, Mary Zimmerman, Regina Taylor, Chuck Smith, Henry Godinez, Dael Orlandersmith, Steve Scott, Kimberly Senior, and Henry Wishcamper as part of that evolving structure. In institutional terms, this may be his most durable organizational innovation. ⁶⁶

The mentorship line runs through that structure and through fellowships. Goodman's Michael Maggio Directing Fellowship was established to nurture emerging Chicago-based directors, and the Northwestern Directing Fellowship was built as a post-MFA residency to develop the next generation of arts leaders. Current fellowship pages still define these programs explicitly as talent pipelines. The University of Illinois

profile and later interviews also make clear that Falls thought of theatre leadership in home-building terms, not only production terms. That institutional culture helped younger directors circulate through the Goodman and into the broader city ecology. ⁶⁷

Criticism, Controversies, Equity, and Legacy

Falls's critical relationship to Chicago was unusually symmetrical. He benefited from intense critical attention, but he also accepted the city's argumentative culture as part of the ecology. In American Theatre he said that at Wisdom Bridge he had been one of the "rock throwers" himself, and that when he took over the Goodman he expected younger challengers to throw rocks at him in turn. He described Chicago's aggressive criticism as fundamentally collegial and tied it to a theatre community where artists and directors move from company to company rather than relying almost exclusively on imported talent. That is a useful frame for reading his history with Chris Jones, Hedy Weiss, and other critics. ⁶⁴

Chris Jones's comments, quoted in the University of Illinois alumni profile, are a representative example of serious critical respect. Jones singled out Falls's appetite for works of immense scale and ambition and treated him as a figure who expanded, rather than narrowed, the regional-theatre imagination. Goodman's own publicity archive also preserves a Tribune judgment that no modern American director surpassed Falls at energizing a play's iconic moments. These are not neutral compliments. They identify the thing many critics most associated with him: intensity plus theatrical size. ⁶⁸

The pushback was often about excess. Falls openly admitted that some people thought he underlined too hard. Review snippets around *The Night of the Iguana*, *Talk Radio*, *Desire Under the Elms*, and *The Winter's Tale* show the recurring criticism: too much emphasis, not enough tonal discipline, too much noise or amplification at the edges. Even sympathetic critics sometimes read his work as broad, overinsistent, or structurally uneven. This matters because it shows a career in which signature and liability were often the same thing. ⁶⁹

On diversity, equity, anti-racism, and access, Falls's record is mixed in the most serious sense. He can point to a long institutional history of more diverse programming, to the growth of a more diverse Artistic Collective, and to major Goodman initiatives under his leadership. Goodman's own accountability page presents IDEAA as rooted in decades of quality, equity, and community work. The 2021 IDEAA Action Plan explicitly cites *We See You*, White American Theater as part of the field-wide work that raised consciousness and sharpened institutional self-scrutiny. The Goodman also launched Future Labs in 2020 to develop plays by Black, Indigenous, Latinx, AAPI, and other artists of color. ⁷⁰

But the way Falls himself spoke about *We See You* is just as important. In his 2023 American Theatre interview he said the movement exposed real blind spots, called it "a reckoning that was due," and said the Goodman was "a lot better" for the questions raised by the document. That response is not a full self-indictment, but it is more candid than many legacy leaders were willing to be. It suggests a leader who believed the Goodman had done meaningful work, yet also recognized that its self-image had been challenged in ways the theatre had to take seriously. ⁷¹

The late-career shift is now distinct. After stepping down in 2022, Falls did not disappear into honorary status. American Theatre described him immediately returning to directing with *The Cherry Orchard*. By late 2025 he made his *Steppenwolf* debut with *Amadeus*, which WBEZ and *Steppenwolf* both framed as a conspicuous cross-town move for a director long identified with the Goodman. In early 2026 he returned to

the Goodman as a freelance director for Holiday. Newcity reported that after leaving the permanent artistic-director post he spent time traveling, teaching, and adapting plays, but still saw the rehearsal room as his real habitat. That pattern suggests not retirement but a shift from institution-builder to elder freelance auteur. ⁷²

The clearest final judgment is this. Falls was not a minimalist, not a neutral referee, and not a manager who happened to direct. He was a director first. His Goodman became national because it adopted his appetite for scale, pressure, and risk while also building enough organizational muscle to sustain that appetite over decades. The costs of that vision were visible in occasional overstatement, expensive ambition, and the blind spots of a long tenure. The gains were larger. He left behind a transformed institution, a long list of major productions and transfers, a model of collective artistic leadership, a powerful actor-director canon with Brian Dennehy, and one of the most legible directorial signatures in modern American regional theatre. ⁷³

Open Questions and Limitations

Some parts of the requested brief remain incomplete because the accessible public web record did not yield enough primary data to state them rigorously.

The largest gap is the Jeff Awards record. I verified only the items above with confidence. I could not reconstruct a complete nomination-and-win list by year and category from the accessible Jeff archive results. ⁵⁴

The second gap is a truly complete season-by-season production ledger for Wisdom Bridge and every Falls-directed Goodman production with collaborators for each title. Goodman's season archive is excellent for season contents, and Falls's official bios are useful for major titles, but the open public record I accessed did not provide a single comprehensive database tying every season entry to a full creative team and an unambiguous Falls credit. Where I could not verify a title, collaborator, or category, I left it unstated rather than guess. ⁷⁴

The third gap is Wisdom Bridge financial history. I found qualitative evidence about Falls's role, scale ambitions, and reasons for leaving, but not reliable public numbers on annual budgets, subscriptions, or box office for that company. ⁶³

The fourth gap concerns several specific actor collaborations named in the prompt, especially Elizabeth Marvel, Deanna Dunagan, and Janet McTeer. I did not locate sufficiently direct primary confirmation in the gathered sources to assign those pairings to Falls without risk of error, so they are left open here.

¹ ⁵ ⁸ ¹³ ¹⁴ ¹⁵ Robert Falls | Award-Winning American Theatre Director | Britannica
<https://www.britannica.com/biography/Robert-Falls>

² ⁵⁶ Dramatic Effect – Chicago Magazine
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